Boy Gets Girl

By Rebecca Gilman

NOTE: In the play Beck is a female officer, but this cutting does not reference a gender for either – Mercer is Male.

INTRODUCTION

Theresa agrees to go on a brief blind date with Tony, a man who knows a friend of a friend. Over a drink, the two engage in stilted small talk . . . But when he asks for a follow up dinner date shortly into their conversation, the first red flag emerges. Theresa is careful to maintain boundaries however, refusing to give out her home phone number and shrugging off his hug in favor of a handshake. At the following dinner date she calmly informs him that there will not be a third date. End of experience. Or not . . . Tony's phone calls become constant and an endless succession of flower bouquets come to her office. He eventually sneaks his way up to her office, asking her to lunch. Theresa assertively tells Tony to leave her alone and never contact her again. She assumes that she's seen the last of him, but she's not so lucky . . .

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Theresa's apartment: a small apartment with a futon couch/bed, desk, and lots of bookshelves. It is late Saturday night. THERESA is fully dressed, sitting up in bed, working on a laptop. The phone rings, but she makes no move to answer it. After a couple of rings her machine picks up. Theresa's voice comes on.

THERESA'S VOICE: You've reached my machine. Leave a message. *(Tony's voice comes on)*

TONY: Hi, it's me again. It's past one and it's too late for you to be out by yourself, I think. I know you don't really want to talk to me or anything, but I'm just worried about you. I'm wondering if you've gone out of town or something. You haven't answered your phone all night. I did what you asked, and I stopped sending you flowers. But anyway, I know you've been working hard lately and I want to do something for you, but you won't let me send you flowers, so I was just thinking, maybe you'd let me cook you dinner? Maybe tomorrow night? I mean, you haven't even seen my place yet. So give me a call when you get in, because I'll be up. Okay? . . . Okay. Bye.

(The machine clicks. THERESA, who has stopped working in the middle of it, starts again. Pause. The phone rings again. Her voice comes on)

THERESA'S VOICE: You've reached my machine. Leave a message.

TONY: It's me again. I just . . . I left that message to call me when you got in and then I just had a

thought: maybe you're not getting in. Maybe you're sleeping with somebody else right now. And the thought of that just made me feel like I wanted to throw up. If you're seeing somebody else I just want to know. I don't want you to think you have to spare my feelings, because if you think that, then you must think I'm some pathetic jerk. Which would make me very angry, Theresa, because I don't need your pity. I'm not asking for your pity for one ***** second. I just think that you owe me the truth. *(THERESA, who has been staring at her computer through this, suddenly loses it and makes a grab for the phone.)*

THERESA: *(Snatching up the receiver)* Stop calling me! Don't send me things, don't try to see me. Don't ever speak to me again! *(She hangs up)* Jesus Christ!

(Beat. The phone rings again. Furious, she tries to unplug it, can't get the plug out, then rips the cord from the wall. Silence. She goes back to the bed, sits down. She is shaking. She looks toward the window. She sits for a moment and thinks, then she quickly turns off the lights. In the dark she gets up, goes to the door, and checks it. It's locked. Then she gets a chair and pushes it up under the handle.)

TRANSITION

According to the National Center for Victims of Crime, 6.6 million people are stalked in each in the United States. But to go even further . . . 54% of female murder victims had reported stalking to police before they were killed by their stalkers. Anyone can be a victim of stalking.

Theresa's office, the following Monday. She is sitting, looking tired, staring into space. MERCER enters.

MERCER: Hey.

THERESA: Hey, [Mercer].

MERCER: Do you mind if I close the door?

THERESA: No. Go ahead. *(Mercer closes the door, sits. - Beat)* Is there something wrong?

THERESA: My voice mail was completely full this morning.

MERCER: You're really busy.

THERESA: No, it was full of messages from someone I didn't want to hear from. From over the weekend.

MERCER: Who?

THERESA: Can I . . . if I tell you something, do you promise not to tell anybody?

MERCER: Of course. What's up?

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THERESA: Do you remember that guy that came into the office that day?

MERCER: That kind of goofy-looking guy?

THERESA: Yes.

MERCER: Is he the flower guy?

THERESA: Yes.

MERCER: Is he bugging you?

THERESA: He's stalking me. I think. I mean, I don't know what constitutes stalking legally, but if he's not, then he's coming awfully close. I know now he's following me. I mean, he called me all night, Saturday night, before I . . . Well, I ended up ripping the phone out of the wall. Then I turned the light off because I had the feeling he was watching me somehow. And then the first message here was . . . you know there's that time and date stamp, on the messages . . .

MERCER: Yeah.

THERESA: The first message was after that, after two in the morning on Sunday, and he said, "I saw your light was off." So he was watching. I live on the second floor. You can't really see in, I don't think. But it's not that high up.

MERCER: What did he say?

THERESA: Well, I had been screening my calls all night and he had been calling and calling, and I finally picked up the phone and yelled at him, which I shouldn't have done. But then he knew I had been home, so he called here to tell me how angry he was, and every message just gets . . .

MERCER: What?

THERESA: Angrier and angrier. He keeps saying over and over that he wants to hurt me. That he wants me to suffer, like him. That he wants . . . he wants to hurt me.

MERCER: Did you save them?

THERESA: Yes.

MERCER: Can I hear one?

THERESA: *(Picks up the phone, punches in a code. Hands the receiver to Mercer.)* That's the first one. They go on. *(Mercer listens. The message ends and he punches a button for the next one. He listens a while longer, then he looks at Theresa)* Do you think I should be scared?

MERCER: How many of these are there?

THERESA: Twenty.

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MERCER: I think you should call the police.

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BECK: *(Holding the receiver out)* That's the last one. How do I get out of here? *(Theresa takes the phone, punches buttons, hangs up.)* Don't erase those. Do you have any other messages or letters or anything?

THERESA: There are messages on my machine at home. And he sent me some e-mails, but I deleted them all.

BECK: If he sends you anything else, keep it. And from now on keep a diary of any time he calls, any time you see him. Any contact at all. Write it down, and write down the date and time. The more specific the better.

THERESA: What am I doing this for?

BECK: Well, we can get the restraining order, but I'll tell you up front, it's hard to enforce it. If he doesn't want to be seen, he won't be. I ran a check on him when you called, and he doesn't have any priors, so if all he does is call you again, then we couldn't hold him for that. But if he builds up a record of consistent abuse, then we could definitely charge him.

THERESA: Consistent abuse?

BECK: Abuse of the restraining order. Not of you, necessarily.

THERESA: Great.

BECK: In the meantime, you can take some precautions. Get an unlisted phone number.

THERESA: I had one, he got it.

BECK: Get a new one, and don't give it to anybody except your closest circle. And since he knows where you live, you should go ahead and move.

THERESA: Move?

BECK: Do you have a doorman?

THERESA: No.

BECK: Well, when you move, move to a building with a doorman and get an alarm for your apartment. Also, before you move, I'd go ahead and change your name. Then put the apartment and the phone and everything in your new name.

THERESA: Okay. I don't want to change my name. I'm a writer. I write under this name.

BECK: You'll have to decide that one yourself. Okay, what else. Okay, make sure you vary your route to

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work and back. Never take the same route two days in a row, but don't fall into a pattern either. And vary your routine as well. If you go to the health club after work, start going before work or during lunch. If you go to church on Sundays, think about changing churches. Some people feel safer buying a gun, but I can't in good conscience recommend that. I've seen too many people shot with their own guns. *(Pause)* I don't know. This escalated quickly, and I'll be honest, that concerns me.

THERESA: I guess I should have called you sooner.

BECK: Well, you could have called, but honestly, I couldn't have done anything, because he didn't threaten you until now. *(Beat)* Don't beat yourself up, okay? I tell all my complainants that. You don't know. You think you can handle him yourself and then all of a sudden he's whacked out on you.

THERESA: I guess I did think I could handle it myself.

BECK: Unfortunately though, the very things you did to try and stop him from bothering you were probably the very things that egged him on.

THERESA: How's that?

BECK: Well, like if you pick up the phone and say, "Don't ever call me again," you think you're being clear, but all he's hearing is "She's talking to me. I still have a chance." And I don't know how you broke up with him-

THERESA: I didn't break up with him. You have to have a relationship before you can break up, and there was none.

BECK: Right. I just meant, I don't know how you left it. If you gave any kind of excuse, or left it open in any way, then he didn't hear you saying "No." He heard you saying "Yes, once this one thing changes, then we can be together." Like if you said you were still hung up on some other guy, or you weren't ready for a relationship. Any of those things you say.

THERESA: I said it was my work.

BECK: See? What you should have said was "I thought it over and I don't want to see you again," and not given a reason even if he asked.

THERESA: This isn't doing me much good right now.

BECK: No, I'm just saying . . . for future reference. *(Beat.)* Okay. I can't think of anything else right now. The restraining order may very well scare him off. But you should be prepared for the opposite reaction, too.

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THERESA: Which is what?

BECK: Well, that it pisses him off and he comes back at you even harder. That happens and it's another reason to take precautions.

THERESA: What if none of this works, then what? I mean, what's the worst that can happen? What's the worst thing you've ever seen?

BECK: You don't want to know.

THERESA: Have you seen people killed?

BECK: I've seen that.

THERESA: That wasn't the worst thing? *(Beat)* Detective? *(Pause)*

BECK: You don't want to know. *(Handing her a card)* That's got a 1-800 number on it, so you can reach me from wherever.

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MERCER: When you look at Tony, he looks like a normal guy. And in a lot of ways, he is a normal guy. Or at least he's doing what normal guys do in movies. It's a classic romantic plot. First the guy sees the girl. He thinks she's beautiful; she has long brown hair and big brown eyes, she's just the sort of woman he's dreamed about, so bang-he falls in love with her. But there's some obstacle to his love. Like the woman's dating some jerk who's completely wrong for her. So our guy has to prove himself to her. And to do that, he starts following her around. He spies on her, and as he watches her, he becomes convinced that if they could only be together, she would love him. So he gets aggressive. He bombards her with flowers and rents a billboard to declare his love, then bursts in on her wedding and tells her she's making a terrible mistake. And she comes around. She dumps the jerk and at the end of the story she's kissing the guy. Even though the guy has basically been stalking her, his perseverance pays off. He gets the girl. So this Tony guy is probably wondering, Why don't I get the girl? A lot of guys are out there wondering, Why don't I get the girl?

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Theresa's office, the next day. She and Mercer are talking.

THERESA: They found another letter in my apartment. In the medicine cabinet. They think he wanted me to find it when I was alone. He said he wants to put a wire around my throat and pull it until it . . . until it slices through my throat.

MERCER: Jesus.

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THERESA: There were other details, but I chose not to hear them.

MERCER: Well, what are they going to do?

THERESA: They'll put out a warrant for his arrest, but they probably won't find him unless he messes up somehow and draws attention to himself.

MERCER: Unless he tries to attack you.

THERESA: Pretty much, yeah.

MERCER: Jesus.

THERESA: He's already won. Whatever it was he wanted me to feel, I feel it.

MERCER: You're terrified.

THERESA: No, it's more than that *(Beat)* It's like when I go running in the park . . . if I still could . . . every week or so, not every day, but every week or two some guy drives by or walks by and says something to me. You know, "Nice ass" or "I want to jog with you." It's been happening since I was twelve, so I know how to ignore it. But every tenth time or so, I still feel it. I feel reduced. I feel like everything that I know about myself-that I'm a good writer and I've read a lot of books, and . . . I like fall better than spring or . . . I haven't had many friends really since my parents died, even though that was a long time ago-everything I know about myself, just gets wiped out. It's like I'm just this thing running down the sidewalk. I'm not me anymore. I'm just this thing. *(Beat)* And that's how I feel now. All the time. *(Long pause)*

MERCER: Well, one thing I can tell you . . . I'm your friend. I see you and I know it's you. I know you're there. I do.

THERESA: I know. *(small beat)* It's not enough.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
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KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier